THE FALKLANDS WAR

ARGENTINA LAUNCHED A MILITARY campaign to invade and occupy South Georgia and the Falkland Islands, disputed British possessions in the South Atlantic, on March 19, 1982. The British opted to retake the islands by military force, which it achieved by mid-June. The British victory was made possible by the rapid deployment of a naval task force across 8,000 miles (12,900 km) of Atlantic Ocean. The task force consisted of two small carriers, *Hermes* and *Invincible*, operating Harrier jump-jets, and ships carrying troops and equipment, screened by destroyers and frigates. A submarine force was sent to keep the Argentinian navy away from an "exclusion zone" around the islands. As the task force drew closer to the Falklands in early May, both sides suffered naval losses. The aging Argentinian cruiser *General Belgrano* was sunk by a submarine while the Royal Navy lost a destroyer to air attack from land-based aircraft. On May 21 British troops landed at San Carlos, but air attacks intensified. Argentinian forces on the Falklands surrendered on June 14, but it proved a close-run conflict. British losses were high, with 15 ships either sunk or badly damaged.



The sinking of HMS Antelope
On May 24, while on air defense duty at the entrance to San Carlos Water, the British frigate HMS *Antelope* was attacked and sunk by two Argentine A-4 Skyhawk jets.

LANDINGS AT SAN CARLOS WATER

THE FALKLANDS WAR



SAN CARLOS LANDINGS

Date	May 21–25, 1982
Location	San Carlos Water, off East Falkland Island
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	ARGENTINA

COMMANDERS

John "Sandy" Woodward	**Ernesto Crespo, Juan Lombardo**

FORCES

Ships: c.100 vessels	**Aircraft:** c.110 attack aircraft

LOSSES

Ships: 1 destroyer, 2 frigates, 1 container ship **Men:** 53	**Aircraft:** 103 **Men:** unknown

The landing of British troops on the Falklands began on May 21, initiating the most intensive phase of the air-sea conflict. The Royal Navy positioned its destroyers and frigates in Falkland Sound to intercept air attacks with their missile defenses, while the carriers *Hermes* and *Invincible*, operating far to the east for fear of Exocet missile attack, flew off Sea Harriers to provide a combat air patrol. The amphibious assault began at dawn with 4,000 men being landed by a variety of amphibious ships around San Carlos bay. Within 24 hours the beachhead had been secured and the land campaign had begun.

The naval forces, however, were still fighting for their lives. Argentinian air attacks began two hours after first light on May 21, the principal attackers being Skyhawk and Mirage fighters flying low-level bombing and strafing runs from bases on the Argentine mainland. The British ships replied with machine gun and cannon fire, as well as numerous Sea Slug, Sea Cat, and Sea Wolf missiles—although many of the missiles suffered technical failures. The County-Class destroyer *Antrim* was hit by a dud bomb that knocked out her surface-to-air missile systems; the Type 22 frigate *Brilliant* was strafed; and the Leander Class frigate *Argonaut* was crippled in the water by multiple bomb strikes. Worse still, the Type 21 frigate *Ardent* was hit by two 1,000 lb (454 kg) bombs and sank. The only compensation was that the Argentine air force had lost 16 aircraft during the first day's fighting, an unsustainable daily loss.

It was the beginning of a difficult week for the British naval forces around San Carlos Water. The frigate *Antelope* was sunk on May 24 and on May 25 the destroyer *Coventry* and frigate *Broadsword* were attacked by waves of A-4 Skyhawks in Falkland

> "I WAS TWO DECKS DOWN AND COULD SEE NO WAY OUT. THE SMOKE WAS SUFFOCATING AND THE DOORS WERE BLOCKED BY FIRE. I WAS CALM AND PREPARED TO DIE."
>
> **CAPTAIN DAVID HART DYKE**, DESCRIBING THE SINKING OF THE HMS *COVENTRY* ON MAY 25, 1982